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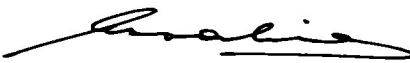
From the editor-in-chief

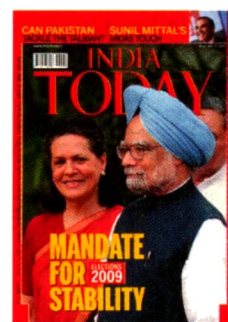
For whatever reason, the result of the just-concluded assembly polls in three states has defied the anti-incumbency trend which had become common in Indian elections. Getting a hat trick in a major state like Maharashtra is unprecedented in the last three decades. In Haryana too, getting a second mandate is as rare. Added to this is the fact that the performance of either of these two governments has been nothing remarkable. Further, all the three candidates for chief ministership were incumbents. In two key states, Maharashtra and Haryana, they were surprise choices when they were elevated and not popular with the state leadership. In Haryana, Congress stalwart Bhajan Lal quit the party in protest when Bhupinder Singh Hooda was made chief minister while Vilasrao Deshmukh is still smarting from having been replaced by the younger, less experienced Ashok Chavan.

With all these considerations it begs the question, why the Congress won? Obviously, a disunited opposition played into the hands of the Congress and its allies but there are clearly other factors which impacted these elections and elevated them beyond local issues and local politics. Our cover story analyses the myriad factors which gave these elections a national significance. More so, since it comes less than six months after storming back to power in the Lok Sabha elections, it represents a major boost to the Sonia Gandhi-led Congress. Indeed, if the BJP lost electoral credibility with its India Shining slogan, it can now be hijacked by the Congress and converted to Sonia Shining. No doubt, strong regional allies like NCP leader Sharad Pawar played a major role in the Maharashtra victory but at the end of the day, much of the credit will be laid at the Congress president's door.

Most Congressmen in Maharashtra, led by Deshmukh and senior Congress leader in charge of the state Digvijay Singh, wanted to go it alone but she along with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh stuck to their strategy to keep allies happy and back them when it matters. Indeed, the near-invisible effect of Dr Manmohan Singh cannot be ignored either. His sober approach and clean image is clearly a plus for the Congress. The results are by no means spectacular but the strategy shows that the Congress can win only if it accommodates key allies like it did in Maharashtra. Since 1998 Sonia has mastered the art of winning elections by keeping allies in good humour. Further, the timing of the triple victory is a huge morale booster for the Congress.

The degree to which the BJP and its ally the Shiv Sena are in disarray is highlighted by the fact that the win in a strategic state like Maharashtra came against the backdrop of farmer suicides, the 26/11 botch-up, floods in Mumbai, job losses and the incumbency factor. This is further aggravated by the worrying rise of the rabid Raj Thackeray's MNS which divided the anti-Congress vote. Admittedly, the role played by Central and state schemes by way of rural doles and subsidies helps but the overall mood in all recent elections, state or Central, suggests that the Congress is on something of a roll and our cover story analyses the larger significance of that development and what it could portend for the future.


(Aroon Purie)



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